

The Remote Data Career Launch Plan

30 days from "skills in the gutter" to first paid remote gig

Daily commitment: 4 hrs learning + 2 hrs profile/applications = 6 hrs/day

Goal: First paid gig (freelance or full-time) within 30-45 days

Target markets: US, Canada, UK, EU, high-paying Asia (Singapore, Japan, UAE)

Reality Check First (Read This Twice)

You're in a great spot, but I won't sugarcoat the math:

- **Junior data scientist roles at US/EU companies** typically require 1-2 years of experience or a finished degree/bootcamp. You'll start applying these aggressively *during* and *after* Moringa, not now.
- **Realistic 30-day target:** Land your first **freelance gig** (\$50-\$300) on Upwork, Fiverr, or via direct outreach. This is 100% doable.
- **Realistic 60-90 day target:** Land a junior remote contract role (\$800-\$2,500/month) at a startup, or stack multiple freelance clients.
- **Realistic 6-month target:** Full-time junior remote role at a mid-size US/EU company (\$25K-\$60K/year, often more with US clients).

The single biggest mindset shift: Stop calling yourself an "aspiring data scientist." Start calling yourself a **Data Analyst**. Here's why it matters:

"Data Scientist"	"Data Analyst"
Implies ML, stats wizardry, PhD-adjacent	Implies SQL, Excel, dashboards, business questions
~1% of job postings for entry level	~30% of job postings for entry level
Competitive with PhDs	Competitive with bootcampers
Average \$130K (US)	Average \$75K (US, still excellent)

You can pivot to "data scientist" once you have Moringa + 1 year of analyst experience. Get hired first.

The Strategic Stack: SQL + Python + One BI Tool

Based on current 2026 hiring trends, this is your most hireable skill combination for the next 30 days:

1. **SQL (60% of your learning time)** — The single most-requested skill in every data job posting. Easier to learn than Python. Lands gigs faster.
2. **Python with Pandas (30%)** — For data cleaning and analysis.
3. **One BI tool (10%)** — Tableau Public (free) or Power BI (free desktop version). Adds dashboarding to your résumé.

Skip ML, deep learning, and statistics theory for now. Moringa teaches those properly. Your job in these 30 days is to be **dangerously employable as a Data Analyst**.

The Revised 30-Day Plan

Daily Time Breakdown

- **Hours 1-4:** Learning (SQL-weighted)
- **Hours 5-6:** Profile building / applications / outreach

You can extend learning hours on weekends. Weekdays, protect the 2-hour profile slot — it's the part most people skip and

it's where the money is.

🌐 WEEK 1 — SQL Foundation + Profile Setup

Day 1 — Setup Everything

- Install: Anaconda, VS Code, Git, DBeaver
- Create accounts: GitHub, LinkedIn (or update yours), Kaggle, Mode Analytics, Wise (for international payments — see Payment section below)
- *Profile time*: Take a clean professional headshot (good lighting, plain background, smile). This single thing increases LinkedIn profile views by 14x.

Day 2-3 — SQL Basics

- SELECT, FROM, WHERE, ORDER BY, LIMIT
- Comparison operators, AND/OR/NOT
- Resources: SQLZoo (free), Mode SQL Tutorial Section 1
- *Profile time*: Write your LinkedIn headline (template in LinkedIn section below)

Day 4-5 — SQL Aggregations

- GROUP BY, HAVING, COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX
- Resources: SQLZoo Aggregates, HackerRank SQL Easy (do 5 problems)
- *Profile time*: Write your LinkedIn About section

Day 6 — SQL JOINS

- INNER JOIN, LEFT JOIN, RIGHT JOIN, FULL JOIN
- This is the most common SQL interview topic. Master it.
- Resources: Mode SQL Tutorial JOINS section
- *Profile time*: Add Skills section to LinkedIn (50 skills max — use them all)

Day 7 — SQL Practice + Python Refresher

- Solve 10 HackerRank SQL problems back-to-back
- Quick Python: variables, lists, dictionaries, for loops, functions
- Resources: freeCodeCamp Python YouTube (first 2 hours)
- *Profile time*: Set up your GitHub profile README (instructions below)

End of Week 1: ✔ You can write basic-to-intermediate SQL. Your LinkedIn looks human. GitHub exists.

🌐 WEEK 2 — Python for Data + First Portfolio Piece

Day 8-9 — Python Essentials for Data

- Lists, dicts, list comprehensions, file I/O
- The 80/20 of Python you'll actually use as an analyst
- *Profile time*: Open Upwork account, complete profile to 100%

Day 10-11 — Pandas Crash Course

- Reading CSVs, .head(), .describe(), filtering, .groupby()
- Resources: Kaggle Learn Pandas course (free, ~4 hours total)
- *Profile time*: Open Fiverr account, draft your first gig (template below)

Day 12 — Data Visualization

- Matplotlib basics, Seaborn for prettier charts
- *Profile time*: Connect with 20 data professionals on LinkedIn (personalized notes, not blank requests)

Day 13-14 — PORTFOLIO PROJECT #1

- Pick a Kaggle dataset that interests you (suggestion: "Sales of Game of Thrones Battle" is small and tells a story; or any e-commerce dataset)
- Build: SQL queries answering 5 business questions + Python notebook with visualizations + a one-page summary in markdown
- Push to GitHub with a polished README
- *Profile time*: Take screenshots of your project and post about it on LinkedIn (this single act gets recruiters DMing you)

End of Week 2: ✔ One portfolio project live. LinkedIn active. Upwork/Fiverr profiles published. You're now technically a "Data Analyst."

🔗 WEEK 3 — BI Tool + Second Portfolio Piece + Start Applying

Day 15-16 — Tableau Public OR Power BI Desktop

- Pick ONE. Tableau Public if you want US/global appeal; Power BI if you want corporate/enterprise.
- Build a dashboard from your Week 2 project
- *Profile time*: Apply to 5 Upwork jobs daily starting today (template in Upwork section)

Day 17-18 — Advanced SQL

- Subqueries, CTEs (WITH clauses), Window functions
- Window functions are interview gold — RANK(), ROW_NUMBER(), LAG(), LEAD()
- Resources: Mode SQL Tutorial Advanced
- *Profile time*: 5 Upwork applications + 2 Reddit r/forhire scans

Day 19-21 — PORTFOLIO PROJECT #2 (Bigger)

- Pick a real-world dataset (e.g., NYC Taxi, Airbnb listings, COVID data)
- Build: 10+ SQL queries answering business questions + Python notebook + Tableau/Power BI dashboard
- Write a blog post on Medium or LinkedIn explaining your findings — this is critical
- *Profile time*: Continue daily applications

End of Week 3: ✔ Two portfolio projects, one with a public dashboard. You've sent ~30 applications. You should have at least 1-2 client conversations going.

🔗 WEEK 4 — Apply Aggressively + Specialize

Day 22-24 — Pick a Niche

- Niching down 10x your conversion rate. Pick ONE: e-commerce analytics, marketing analytics, finance/fintech, healthcare, or SaaS metrics.
- Refactor your LinkedIn headline and Upwork profile to mention this niche
- Build a tiny third project specifically in this niche (even a 4-hour notebook works)

Day 25-27 — Cold Outreach Phase

- Find 50 small startups in your niche (use AngelList/Wellfound, LinkedIn search "data analyst" + small companies)
- Send personalized DMs to founders/hiring managers (template in Cold Outreach section)
- Continue Upwork applications daily

Day 28-30 — Interview Prep + Polish

- Practice common SQL interview questions (StrataScratch free tier, LeetCode SQL)
- Prepare your "Tell me about yourself" pitch (30 seconds)
- Continue applying. Take any first-call interviews you can get for practice.

End of Week 4: ✔ ~80 applications sent. ~50 cold DMs sent. 3 portfolio projects. Ready for Moringa Day 1 with momentum.

🏠 LinkedIn Optimization (The Recruiter Magnet)

LinkedIn is where 90% of remote tech recruiters search. Treat it like SEO.

Your Profile Photo

- Plain background, good lighting, smile, dressed business-casual
- Use [PhotoFeeler](#) (free) to test which photo scores best

Your Banner

- Free option: [Canva](#) → search "LinkedIn banner data"
- Make it relevant: data visualizations, code snippets, or just your name + tagline

Your Headline (CRITICAL — most-read part of your profile)

Bad: "Aspiring Data Scientist | Student"

Good: "Data Analyst | SQL, Python, Tableau | Helping startups make data-driven decisions"

Better: "Data Analyst specializing in [your niche] | SQL × Python × Tableau | Open to remote opportunities"

Why? Recruiters search by keywords. "Open to remote" is a magnet phrase. Specifying skills makes you discoverable.

Your About Section (template)

I help [your niche, e.g., e-commerce startups] turn messy data into clear business decisions.

🔧 Skills: SQL (advanced), Python (Pandas, NumPy), Tableau, statistical analysis

📁 Recent work: [Link or mention your portfolio project]

🎓 Currently: Building expertise via Moringa School's Data Science program (in partnership with Flatiron School)

🌐 Open to: Remote freelance projects and full-time roles globally

Let's talk if you need someone who can write the SQL, do the analysis, AND explain it to non-technical stakeholders.

✉️ [your email]

Skills Section

Add ALL 50 skills. Top 3 should be: SQL, Python, Data Analysis. Then add Tableau, Power BI, Pandas, Microsoft Excel, Data Visualization, Statistical Analysis, Database Management, ETL, Dashboards, Business Intelligence, etc.

"Open to Work" Setting

Turn it ON for recruiters only (not visible publicly). LinkedIn → Profile → Open to → Finding a new job. Specify "Remote" and your target geographies.

Daily LinkedIn Habit (15 min/day)

- Post once every 3 days about something you learned (be specific: "Today I learned how SQL window functions can solve X problem...")
- Comment thoughtfully on 5 posts from people in your target industry
- Connect with 5 new people daily (data analysts, engineering managers, founders)

This builds you to ~500 connections in 90 days. The algorithm starts pushing your posts to recruiters once you cross ~300.

🐙 GitHub: Your Real Portfolio

Recruiters at serious companies will check your GitHub before responding. Make it not embarrassing.

Your GitHub Profile README

Create a special repo with the same name as your username (e.g., if your username is `johndoe` , create a repo called `johndoe`). The README in this repo shows on your profile page.

Template:

```
### Hi, I'm [Your Name] 🙋  
  
📁 **Data Analyst** based in Kenya, working with clients globally  
🔧 **Tools:** SQL, Python (Pandas, NumPy), Tableau, Power BI  
🎓 Currently studying Data Science at Moringa School  
  
#### Featured Projects  
- 📊 [E-commerce Sales Analysis](link) — SQL + Python project finding revenue insights  
- 📊 [Airbnb Pricing Dashboard](link) — Tableau dashboard with pricing recommendations  
  
#### Get in touch  
✉️ your.email@example.com | 🌐 [LinkedIn](link)
```

Repository Standards (every project needs these)

- **README.md** with: project goal, tools used, key findings, screenshots
- Clean, commented code
- Sample data or link to dataset
- A `requirements.txt` for Python projects

The "Green Squares" Trick

Commit something to GitHub every single day. Even a typo fix. Recruiters look at your contribution graph as a proxy for "is this person actually coding?"

👉 Upwork Profile (Where You'll Get Your First Gig)

Critical setup steps

1. **Title:** "Data Analyst | SQL & Python | Building Dashboards for Startups"
2. **Hourly rate:** Start at \$15-20/hr. Yes, it's low. You'll raise it after 5-10 jobs. Below \$15 attracts bad clients; above \$25 with no reviews gets ignored.
3. **Profile photo:** Same one as LinkedIn for consistency.
4. **Video introduction (optional but +50% conversion):** 30-second video introducing yourself. Phone camera is fine.

Profile Overview Template

I help businesses make sense of their data using SQL, Python, and Tableau.

What I do:

- ✓ Write SQL queries to extract insights from your database
- ✓ Clean and analyze data with Python and Pandas
- ✓ Build dashboards in Tableau or Power BI
- ✓ Deliver clear, business-focused reports

Recent projects:

- Analyzed e-commerce sales data → identified \$X opportunity
- Built dashboard tracking 10 KPIs for marketing team

I'm based in Kenya (GMT+3) — convenient for both US and European clients.
Strong English. Quick turnaround. Direct communication.

Let's discuss your project — message me to chat!

Portfolio

Upload your 3 portfolio projects with screenshots and descriptions.

Application Strategy (this is where 90% of people fail)

Don't apply to 50 jobs with the same template. Apply to 5-7 jobs with hyper-personalized cover letters.

Cover letter formula:

Hi [Their name if visible],

[One sentence showing you read their post — reference a specific detail.]

I can help with this. Here's how I'd approach it:

1. [Specific step]
2. [Specific step]
3. [Specific step]

I've done similar work — here's a relevant project: [link]

Happy to do a quick free 15-min call to discuss. When works for you?

Best,

[Your name]

Sweet spot jobs to target:

- "Data analyst for small e-commerce store"
- "SQL queries needed for reporting"

- "Build me a dashboard in Tableau"
- "Clean up this messy spreadsheet" (yes, these pay)

Avoid: "Senior data scientist with 5+ years," anything ML-heavy, jobs with 100+ applicants already.

🌐 Fiverr Profile (Passive Income Stream)

Fiverr works differently — clients come to YOU based on gig listings.

Your First 3 Gigs (post all 3)

1. **"I will write SQL queries and reports for your database"** (\$25 starting)
2. **"I will clean and analyze your data using Python and Pandas"** (\$30 starting)
3. **"I will build a Tableau dashboard from your data"** (\$50 starting)

Gig Optimization

- Title with keywords (Fiverr is a search engine)
- 3 packages: Basic, Standard, Premium (Fiverr forces you to)
- 3 portfolio images per gig (use your project screenshots)
- Tags: data analysis, SQL, Python, Tableau, dashboard, data cleaning

Reality

First Fiverr order takes 2-6 weeks. Don't rely on it for instant income — set it up and forget it while you push Upwork hard.

🔥 Reddit Communities (Where Hidden Gigs Live)

Subreddits to join NOW

For finding gigs/jobs:

- **r/forhire** — Use the "[Hiring]" filter. Post your own "[For Hire]" thread once you have a portfolio.
- **r/remotefs** — Remote job listings, mostly tech
- **r/jobbit** — Curated remote tech jobs
- **r/slavelabour** — Don't be put off by name. Often has small data tasks. Good practice money.
- **r/donedirtcheap** — Similar, micro-gigs
- **r/freelance** — Community advice, occasional gigs

For learning + networking:

- **r/dataanalysis** — Where junior analysts hang out
- **r/datascience** — Higher-level discussions
- **r/SQL** — SQL help and discussion
- **r/learnpython** — Helpful community
- **r/learnSQL** — Free SQL resources shared daily
- **r/cscareerquestions** — Career advice (US-skewed)
- **r/cscareerquestionsEU** — European job market
- **r/digitalnomad** — Tax/payment tips for working internationally

How to actually use Reddit

1. **Build karma first** (you need karma to post in many subs). Comment helpfully for a week before posting.
2. **In r/forhire** — Filter [Hiring] posts. Look for "data," "SQL," "Python," "analysis." Reply directly to OP, don't comment publicly first.
3. **Your "For Hire" post template:**

[For Hire] Data Analyst — SQL, Python, Tableau (\$15-25/hr)

Hi! I'm a data analyst based in Kenya, available for remote work in any timezone.

Services:

- SQL queries and database analysis
- Data cleaning with Python/Pandas
- Tableau & Power BI dashboards
- Excel/CSV analysis and reporting

Portfolio: [GitHub link]

LinkedIn: [link]

Rate: \$15-25/hr depending on project complexity

Available: 30+ hrs/week

DM me to discuss your project!

Post this once a week (most subs allow weekly).

The "Higher Tier" Platforms (Better Pay, Harder to Get In)

Apply to all of these in Week 3-4. They have screening but pay 3-10x Upwork rates.

Vetted Talent Platforms

- **Toptal** (toptal.com) — Top 3% claim. 5-step vetting. \$60-200/hr. Apply when you have 6+ months experience.
- **Arc.dev** (arc.dev) — Vetted remote devs/data folks. Easier than Toptal. Worth applying now.
- **Turing** (turing.com) — AI-matches you to US companies. Take their assessments NOW (free) — they take ~1 week to process. Long-term contracts.
- **A.Team** (a.team) — Senior, harder to crack. Apply later.

Remote-First Job Boards

- **We Work Remotely** (weworkremotely.com) — Largest remote job board. Apply to junior data roles.
- **Remote OK** (remoteok.com) — Similar, tech-heavy
- **Wellfound** (wellfound.com), formerly AngelList — Startup jobs. Many remote. Junior-friendly.
- **Himalayas** (himalayas.app) — Newer, growing fast, less competition
- **JustRemote** (justremote.co)
- **Working Nomads** (workingnomads.com)

Niche/Specialized

- **DataYoshi** — Data-specific jobs
- **Kaggle Jobs** — Posted occasionally, high-quality
- **Y Combinator's Work at a Startup** (workatastartup.com) — Junior YC startup roles, often remote

Zero-fee Platforms (you keep 100%)

- **Contra** (contra.com) — 0% fees. Newer, growing.
- **Hubstaff Talent** — 0% fees. Less traffic.
- **LinkedIn Services** — Free, integrated with LinkedIn

The Cold Outreach Strategy (Most Underrated)

Mass-applying converts at ~1%. Cold outreach to specific people converts at ~10%.

Step 1: Find 50 targets weekly

- Search LinkedIn for: "Founder" + small companies in your niche (1-50 employees)

- Use [Hunter.io](#) or [Apollo.io](#) (free tiers) to find emails
- Wellfound's "Companies" section — filter by size and remote-friendly

Step 2: The DM/email template

```
Subject: Quick data question for [Company name]

Hi [Name],

I noticed [Company] is in [their space] — saw your recent [post/launch/news].

I'm a data analyst (SQL, Python, Tableau) helping startups like yours turn raw data into clear decisions. I recently [one-sentence project win, e.g., "built a churn analysis dashboard for an e-commerce client that identified 2 high-impact retention levers"].

Would it be useful to chat for 15 minutes about your data setup? Even if it's not a fit, I'm happy to share 1-2 quick ideas based on what you're building.

Best,
[Your name]
[Portfolio link] | [LinkedIn]
```

Send 10/day. Expect 1-2 replies. 1 in 5 replies leads to a paid project.

💰 Getting Paid (Critical for Kenyans)

International clients won't send M-Pesa. You need:

Recommended setup

1. **Wise (formerly TransferWise)** — Get USD, EUR, GBP virtual accounts. Receive payments like a local. Lowest fees. Withdraw to KES. **Open this Day 1.**
2. **Payoneer** — Required by Upwork and Fiverr. Open it.
3. **Deel** — For full-time remote roles. Companies hire you as contractor through Deel. They handle compliance.
4. **PayPal** — Has issues in Kenya for receiving (you can send but receiving has restrictions). Avoid relying on it.

Tax note

Kenyan freelancers earning from abroad are required to report income to KRA. Consult an accountant once you're earning consistently. Not a concern in your first month, but plan for it.

🌐 Your Kenya Time Zone Advantage

You're at GMT+3. This is actually a hiring superpower most Kenyans don't pitch:

Region	Their Hours (your local time)	Pitch
UK/Ireland	11am-7pm UK = 1pm-9pm KE	"Full overlap with your workday"
EU mainland	9am-5pm CET = 11am-7pm KE	"Same business hours"
US East Coast	9am-5pm EST = 5pm-1am KE	"Available evenings"
US West Coast	9am-5pm PST = 8pm-4am KE	Acknowledge async work
UAE/Singapore	Aligned/close	"Real-time collaboration"

Mention this in your pitches. "Based in Kenya (GMT+3), with strong overlap with European business hours" is a feature, not a bug.

AI Tools to Accelerate Everything

You're competing with people who use these. So should you.

For learning faster

- **Claude / ChatGPT** — Ask for SQL practice problems with answers, get code reviewed, explain concepts
- **DataLemur, StrataScratch** — Real interview SQL problems

For your work

- **GitHub Copilot** — Free for students. Auto-complete code while you learn.
- **Cursor** — AI-powered code editor

For your business

- **Loom** — Free screen recording. Explain projects to clients with video.
- **Notion** — Free. Track applications, clients, learning.
- **Calendly** — Free. Let clients book calls without back-and-forth.

Important: Use AI to learn faster, not to fake skills. Clients catch this fast. Type your own code. Use AI to debug and explain.

Scams & Red Flags to Avoid

These will target you on Upwork, LinkedIn, and Reddit:

- **"Pay \$X for a course/certification to get hired"** — 100% scam if unsolicited
- **"Send a sample" for a 4-hour task with no payment** — That's free labor. Decline politely.
- **Telegram/WhatsApp recruiter who can't verify their company** — Almost always fake/MLM
- **"Buy our crypto/data for guaranteed returns"** — Run
- **Clients who want to pay outside the platform** on first job — Upwork bans this and scammers love it
- **"\$5,000/month, just submit your bank details"** — Identity theft

If a deal feels too good in week 1, it is.

Daily Schedule Template

Print this. Stick it on your wall.

6:00 AM	Wake, light exercise, breakfast
7:00 AM	Hour 1 — Learning (SQL focus)
8:00 AM	Hour 2 — Learning (hands-on practice)
9:00 AM	Break (15 min walk, hydrate)
9:15 AM	Hour 3 — Learning (Python or Tableau)
10:15 AM	Hour 4 — Practice problems
11:15 AM	Lunch + LinkedIn scrolling (look at posts in your niche)
3:00 PM	Hour 5 — Apply to jobs / cold outreach
4:00 PM	Hour 6 — Build portfolio / write LinkedIn post
5:00 PM	Done! Rest of day yours.
Evening	Optional: Read industry blogs, watch StatQuest, or just rest.

Adjust to your real schedule. The point is: protect deep work hours, separate learning from applications, don't burn out.

The 30-Day Success Metrics

By Day 30, you should have:

- [] 3 portfolio projects on GitHub with READMEs
- [] 1 published Tableau Public dashboard
- [] LinkedIn at 100% completion, 200+ connections, 3+ posts
- [] Upwork profile live with 3+ portfolio items, 20+ applications sent
- [] Fiverr with 3 active gigs
- [] 50+ cold outreach messages sent
- [] At least 5 client conversations started
- [] 1 paid gig (or one in negotiation)
- [] SQL: comfortable with JOINS, aggregations, window functions
- [] Python: comfortable with Pandas basics
- [] Wise + Payoneer accounts ready to receive money

If you hit even 70% of this, you're crushing it.

Final Words

I'm not going to pretend this is going to be easy. It's a tough sprint, especially while your skills are still building. But two things are true:

1. **Most people don't do this.** They learn for 6 months in isolation, then panic-apply. You're building skills AND visibility AND momentum simultaneously. That's the cheat code.
2. **The hardest gig to land is the first one.** After your first paid project, getting the second is dramatically easier. Reviews compound. Confidence compounds. Network compounds.

When Moringa starts in a month, you'll already be earning, already have a portfolio, and the bootcamp content will reinforce what you've learned. That's the position you want to be in.

Now stop reading. Open SQLZoo. Start.

Good luck. You've got this. 🌍